
ܡܝܬܬܐ ܕܐܕܡ • THE TESTAMENT OF ADAM

INTRODUCTION

The *Testament of Adam* is a short Christian, pseudepigraphal work from late antiquity; it was likely composed in Syriac, though it now survives in numerous languages and recensions.

The document is comprised of two main parts, usually called the *Horarium* and the *Prophecy* by modern scholars. It is conventionally divided into four chapters, with the *Horarium* comprising the first two chapters and the *Prophecy* as chapter three. What we often call the fourth chapter is an additional section, the *Hierarchy*, which only appears in one manuscript (*Vatican Syriac 164*, dated at 1072 CE) and was almost certainly not part of any original document.

The Syriac (*BM Add. 14,624*, early 9th Century CE, Chs 1–3 only) and Greek (*Paris Codex Greek 2419*, 15th/16th Century) texts here presented are from the [Online Critical Pseudepigrapha](#) (OCP). Note that the order of Chs 1 & 2 in the Greek text here cited is inverted in respect of that of the Syriac text. The Syriac text for Ch. 4 is a version of M. Kmosko's 1907 transcription of 'Fragment 3' and will likely contain errors.

AUTHORSHIP AND DATES

There is no consensus about the dating of the *Testament of Adam*. The earliest known manuscript is from the 9th Century CE (Syriac, as presented here) and the combining of the *Horarium* and the *Prophecy* must have happened sometime before that. If the text of *Transitus Mariae* that Lewis edited is from the 5th Century, as she was led to believe, this might be the earliest witness, or at least to the *Prophecy*. In the Coptic *Apocalypse of Elijah* (3:1–8), a list of the antichrist's miracles is found that resembles the list of Jesus' miracles in 3:1. On this basis, some tentatively suggest that the *Prophecy* was composed in the 3rd Century CE and dates the *Horarium* no later than that, though possibly earlier. James Charlesworth believes that the work evidences many features that suggest a date of composition in the late 2nd Century CE but he only points specifically to the motif of Cain's jealousy over his sister (3:5) as a possible expression of early Syrian asceticism.

תְּסֻמָּת אָדָם 1

1 הַשָּׁעָה הַרְּבִיעִית הִיא תְּהִלַּת הַדֵּמֹנִים; בְּהַשָּׁעָה הַזֹּאת, לֹא יַזְכִּיקוּ וְלֹא יַשָּׁחֲרוּ אִישׁ אֶת אֶחָד מֵאִישׁ. 2 הַשָּׁעָה הַשֵּׁנִית הִיא תְּהִלַּת הַיּוֹנִתִּים. 3 הַשָּׁעָה הַשְּׁלִישִׁית הִיא תְּהִלַּת הַדָּגִים וְהַשֵּׁרָפִים וְהַאֵשׁ וְכָל הַמַּדְּבָרִים הַנִּמְצָאִים בְּעִמְקֵי הָאָרֶץ. 4 הַשָּׁעָה הָרְבִיעִית הִיא תְּהִלַּת הַסֵּרָפִים. וְכֵן, יָדָעְתִּי לִשְׁמֹעַ, לִפְנֵי שֶׁחָטֵאתִי, הַקוֹל שֶׁל כַּנְּפֵיהֶם בְּגֶן הָעֵדֶן, כְּשֶׁהַסֵּרָפִים יִכְרְשׁוּ אֶת קוֹל תְּהִלָּתָם הַשְּׁלִישִׁית. אֲבָל, אַחֲרֵי שֶׁעָוַרְתִּי עַל הַחֹק, לֹא שָׁמַעְתִּי עוֹד אֶת הַקוֹל הַזֶּה. 5 הַשָּׁעָה הַחֲמִישִׁית הִיא תְּהִלַּת הַמַּיִם הַנִּמְצָאִים מִלְּפָנֵי הַשָּׁמַיִם. וְכֵן, יָדָעְתִּי, יַחְדָּם עִי וְהַמַּלְאָכִים, לִשְׁמֹעַ הַקוֹל שֶׁל גַּלְגָּלֵי הַיָּם הַגְּדוֹלִים, אֵימָנָה שֶׁתִּזְכָּרְתֶּם לִלְבֹּשׁ חֹמֶת לְפָנֵינוּ. 6 הַשָּׁעָה הַשִּׁשִּ�ית הִיא הַבְּנֵיית הַעֲנָנִים וְהַיִּר הַגָּדוֹל שֶׁבָּא בְּאֶמְצֵית הַלַּיְלָה. 7 הַשָּׁעָה הַשְּׁבִיעִית הִיא הַמַּשְׁרָה בְּקִיּוֹמָם.

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¹ The first hour of the night is the praise of the demons; at that hour, they do not injure or harm any man. ² The second hour is the praise of the doves. ³ The third hour is the praise of the fish and of fire and of all the lower depths. ⁴ The fourth hour is the “holy, holy, holy” praise of the seraphim. And so, I used to hear, before I sinned, the sound of their wings in Paradise, when the seraphim would beat them to the sound of their triple praise. But, after I transgressed against the law, I no longer heard that sound. ⁵ The fifth hour is the praise of the waters above heaven. And so, I, together with the angels, used to hear the sound of mighty waves, a sign that would prompt them to lift a hymn of praise to the Creator. ⁶ The sixth hour is the construction of clouds and of the great fear the comes in the middle of the night. ⁷ The seventh hour is the viewing of their powers

TESTAMENT OF ADAM 1

- ¹ For this verse, the *Paris Codex* (wherein it is **Chapter 2**, v. 1) reads, “The first hour ... in which the demons praise God, neither doing wrong nor tormented.” (ὥρα α΄ ... ἐν ᾗ οἱ δαίμονες αἰνοῦντες τὸν θεὸν οὔτε ἀδικοῦσιν οὔτε κολάζουσιν.)
- ² Here, the *Paris Codex* seems to have a version of v. 3, “The second hour ... in which is the fish praise God, and fire in the depths, and dragons and ... and fire.” (ὥρα β΄ ... ἐν ᾗ ὑμνοῦσιν οἱ ἰχθύες τὸν θεόν, καὶ τὸ τοῦ πυρὸς βάθος· ἐν ᾗ ὀφείλει στοιχειοῦσθαι ἀποτελέσματα εἰς δράκοντας καὶ ... καὶ πῦρ.)
- ³ The text of the *Paris Codex* is different, “The third hour ... in praise of snakes and dogs ... and fire.” (ὥρα γ΄ ... ἐν ᾗ αἰνοῦσιν ὄφεις καὶ κύνεις καὶ πῦρ.)
- ⁴ The *Paris Codex* has, “The fourth hour ... in the morning, the demons pass through tombs and he who goes there will be harmed, afraid, and terrified by the minds of demons; in the morning, one will be haunted by these things ... and by every magical thing.” (ὥρα δ΄ ... ἐν ᾗ διέρχονται δαίμονες ἐν τοῖς μνήμασιν, καὶ ἐρχόμενος ἐκεῖσε βλαβήσεται καὶ φόβον καὶ φρίκην ἐκ τῆς τῶν δαιμόνων λήψεται φαντασίας· ἐν ᾗ ὀφείλει στοιχειοῦσθαι ἀποτελέσματα ... καὶ παντὸς γοητικοῦ πράγματος.)
- ⁵ Here, the *Paris Codex* vaguely concurs with the *Syriac MSS*, reading, “The fifth hour ... when the waters praise the God of heaven.” (ὥρα ε΄ ... ἐν ᾗ αἰνοῦσιν τὰ ὕδατα τὸν θεὸν τοῦ οὐρανοῦ.)
- ⁶ The *Paris Codex* reads, “The sixth hour ... one should be quiet and rest because one is afraid.” (ὥρα ζ΄ ... ὅτε δέον ἡσυχάζειν καὶ ἀναπαῦσαι, διότι ἔχει φόβον.)
- ⁷ The *Paris Codex* vaguely concurs with the *Syriac MSS*, reading, “In the seventh hour ... all animals rest. If a clean person takes NARON (water) and a priest throws it, mixed with oil and sanctified, and anoints a nearby sick man with it, he will be free of the disease.” (ὥρα ζ΄ ... ἐν ᾗ ἀναπαύει πάντα {τὰ} ζῶα

1. **הַיְּהוּדִים** (הַיְּהוּדִים) – The Jews.
 2. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 3. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 4. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 5. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 6. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 7. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 8. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 9. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 10. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 11. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.
 12. **וְהַיְּהוּדִים** (וְהַיְּהוּדִים) – And the Jews.

while the waters are asleep. At that hour, the waters *can be* taken up and the priest of God mixes them with consecrated oil and anoints the afflicted and they rest. ⁸ The eighth hour is the sprouting up of the grass of the earth while dew descends from heaven. ⁹ The ninth hour is the praise of the cherubim. ¹⁰ The tenth hour is the praise of human beings, and the gate of heaven is opened through which the prayers of all living things enter, and they worship and depart. And at that hour whatever a man will ask of God is given to him when the seraphim and the roosters beat their wings. ¹¹ The eleventh hour there is joy in all the earth when the sun rises from Paradise and shines forth upon creation. ¹² The twelfth hour is the waiting for incense, and silence is imposed on all the ranks of fire and wind until all the priests burn incense to his divinity. And at that time all the heavenly powers are dismissed. The End of the Hours of the Night.

ταῦτα. ἐάν τις ἄνθρωπος καθαρὸς ἀρπάσῃ **וַיִּרְבֵּ** (νέρον) καὶ βάλλῃ αὐτὸ ὁ ἱερεὺς καὶ μίξῃ μετ' ἐλαίου καὶ ἀγιάσῃ αὐτὸ καὶ ἀλείψῃ ἀπ' αὐτοῦ ἀσθενῇ ἀγρυπνοῦντα παρευθὺ τῆς νόσου ἀπαλλαγήσεται.)

⁸ The *Paris Codex* text for this verse is incomplete and difficult: ὥρα ἡ' ... ἐν ἧ' δὲ ἀποτελοῦμεν στοιχεῖον περὶ ... καὶ παντοίων φυτῶν. ("The eighth hour ... we are a symbol about ... and all kinds of plants.")

⁹ The *Paris Codex* has much of this verse missing, reading, “The ninth hour ... in which nothing will happen.” (ὥρα θ' ... ἐν ᾗ τελεῖται οὐδέν.)

¹⁰ There is no text present for this verse in the *Paris Codex*.

¹¹ The *Paris Codex* reads, “The eleventh hour ... in which the gates of heaven are opened and man, becoming obedient, is born; in which the angels and cherubim and seraphim fly on wings with a voice; and there is joy in heaven and on earth and the sun rises in Eden.” (ὥρα ἰα’ ... ἐν ἣ ἀνοίγονται αἱ πύλαι τοῦ οὐρανοῦ καὶ ἄνθρωπος ἐν κατανύξει γενόμενος εὐήκοος γενήσεται· ἐν ταύτῃ πέτονται ταῖς πτέρυξιν σὺν ἡχῷ οἱ ἄγγελοι καὶ χερουβίμ καὶ σεραφίμ· καὶ ἐστὶν χαρὰ ἐν οὐρανῷ καὶ γῇ· ἀνατέλλει δὲ καὶ ὁ ἥλιος ἐξ Ἑδέμ.)

¹² The Paris Codex has, “The twelfth hour ... the ranks of fire rest. These are the names of the hours; therefore, to those who have truly understood these things, nothing ... of such things will be hidden but all will be subject to them.” (ὥρα ἰβ’ ... ἐν ἧ ἀναπαύονται τὰ πύρινα τάγματα. αὐταῖ εἰσιν αἱ ὀνομασίαι τῶν ὥρῶν· τῷ οὖν καλῶς ταῦτα νοήσαντι οὐδὲν ... τοιούτων ἀποκρυβήσεται ἀλλὰ πάντα ὑποταγήσονται.)

תְּסֻמָּת אָדָם ב

1 הַשָּׁעָה הַרְּבִיעִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַשָּׁמַיִת. 2 הַשָּׁעָה הַשֵּׁנִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַמַּלְאָכִית. 3 הַשָּׁעָה הַשְּׁלִישִׁית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית. 4 הַשָּׁעָה הָרְבִיעִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַבְּהֵמָיִית. 5 הַשָּׁעָה הַחֲמִישִׁית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַשָּׁמַיִת הַלְּבָנָה. 6 הַשָּׁעָה הַשִּׁשִּ�ית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַשָּׁמַיִת הַלְּבָנָה. 7 הַשָּׁעָה הַשְּׁבִיעִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַשָּׁמַיִת הַלְּבָנָה. 8 הַשָּׁעָה הַחֲמִישִׁית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַשָּׁמַיִת הַלְּבָנָה. 9 הַשָּׁעָה הַשִּׁשִּ�ית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַשָּׁמַיִת הַלְּבָנָה. 10 הַשָּׁעָה הַשְּׁבִיעִית הִיא הַתְּפִלָּה הַחַיִּית הַשָּׁמַיִת הַלְּבָנָה.

TESTAMENT OF ADAM 2

1 The first hour of the day is the petition of the heavenly ones. 2 The second hour is the prayer of the angels. 3 The third hour is the praise of the birds. 4 The fourth hour is the praise of the beasts. 5 The fifth hour is the praise that is above heaven. 6 The sixth hour is the praise of the cherubim who plead against the sin of our human nature. 7 The seventh hour is the entry and exit from the presence of God, when the prayers of all living things enter and they worship and depart. 8 The eighth hour is the praise of fire and of the waters. 9 The ninth hour is the entreaty of those angels who stand before the throne of majesty. 10 The tenth hour is the visitation of the waters when the spirit descends and broods on the waters and on the fountains. And, if the spirit of the Lord did not descend and brood on the waters and on the fountains, human beings would be injured and everyone the demons saw they would injure. And at that hour the waters (are)

TESTAMENT OF ADAM 2

- 1 The Greek text for this verse, as quoted by Cedrenus, reads, "At the first hour of the day, the first prayer is said in heaven." (ὥρα πρώτη ἡμερινῇ πρώτη εὐχή ἐπιτελεῖται ἐν τῷ οὐρανῷ.)
- 2 Cedrenus has just, "The second is for the angels." (δευτέρῃ εὐχῇ ἀγγέλων.)
- 3 Here, Cedrenus concurs with the Syriac MSS, reading, "The third is for the prayer of birds." (τρίτῃ εὐχῇ πτηνῶν.)
- 4 Cedrenus has, "The fourth is for the prayer of animals." (τετάρτῃ εὐχῇ κτηνῶν.)
- 5 Cedrenus appears to repeat v. 4 here, reading, "The fifth is for the prayer of beasts." (πεμπτῇ εὐχῇ θηρίων.) Cf. #4.
- 6 Cedrenus reads, "The sixth, the angels defend and judge all creation." (ἕκτῃ ἀγγέλων παράστασις καὶ διάκρισις πάσης κτίσεως.)
- 7 Cedrenus here reads, "The seventh, is the angels entry and exit from God." (ἑβδόμῃ ἀγγέλων εἴσοδος πρὸς θεὸν καὶ ἔξοδος ἀγγέλων.)
- 8 Cedrenus has, "The eighth is [for the] praise and sacrifice of the angels." (ὀγδόῃ αἵνεσις καὶ θυσίαι ἀγγέλων.)
- 9 Cedrenus has, "The ninth [is when] the worship of men is born." (ἐννάτῃ δέησις καὶ λατρεία ἀνθρώπου.)
- 10 For this verse, Cedrenus reads, "The tenth, bishops of the waters and prayers of heavenly and earthly beings." (δεκάτῃ ἐπισκοπαὶ ὑδάτων καὶ δεήσεις οὐρανίων καὶ ἐπιγείων.)

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taken up and the priest of God mixes them with consecrated oil and
 anoints those who are afflicted and they are restored and healed.
¹¹ The eleventh hour is the exultation and joy of the righteous. ¹² The
 twelfth hour, the hour of the evening, is the entreaty of human
 beings, for the gracious will of God, the Lord of all.

¹¹ Cedrenus reads, “The eleventh, confession and joy of all.” (ένδεκάτη ἀνθομολόγησις καὶ ἀγαλλίασις πάντων.)

¹² Cedrenus ends his quotation here, with, “The twelfth, resistance[?] of people to good fortune.” (δωδεκάτη ἔντευξις ἀνθρώπων εἰς εὐδοκίας.)

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TESTAMENT OF ADAM 3

¹ Adam said to Seth his son: “I have heard, my son, that God will come to the world after a long time. He will be conceived by a virgin, wear a body, and be born like a man and mature like a child. He will perform signs and wonders upon earth – walking upon the waves of the sea, rebuking the winds so they abate, beckoning the waves so they cease *rolling*, opening *the eyes* of the blind, cleansing lepers, causing the deaf to hear, giving speech to the mute, straightening those who are bent, strengthening the paralyzed, finding the lost, expelling devils, casting out demons.

2 “For, he said to me in Paradise, after I had plucked some of the fruit that concealed Death within it, “Adam, Adam, do not be afraid! You wished to become *like* a god. Therefore, I shall make you into a god – not now but after a period of many years. Then, I shall deliver you over to Death, and the maggot and the worm will consume your body.”

³ “I answered, saying to him, “Why, my Lord?” He said to me, “Because you hearkened to the words of the serpent, you and your descendants shall serve as food for the serpent. But, after a brief time, mercy shall be shown to you; for, you were created in my image and I will not abandon you to waste away in Sheol. For your sake, I shall be born from the virgin Miriam; and, for your sake, I shall experience Death and enter the realm of Death. For your sake, I shall fashion

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¹ The numerous paragraph separators (❖) in the *Syriac MSS* here are difficult to explain in terms of modern English.

² Reeves' translation does not include the word, '*like*' before the 1st instance of '*a god*'.

³ The double paragraph separators (❖❖) in the *Syriac MSS* (in vv. 3–4) are difficult to explain in terms of modern English.

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⁵ ይህንን ስሜት ለማድረግ ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል
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 ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል

⁶ ይህንን ስሜት ለማድረግ ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል
 ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል
 ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል
 ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል
 ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል
 ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል
 ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል
 ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል ስለሚችል

new heavens and I shall set your descendants in *positions of* authority
 among them. ⁴ After three days in the grave, I shall resuscitate the
 body that I wore on your account and I shall set you at the right hand
 of my divine station, and I shall make you divine like you wished. I
 accept *this* freely, and shall restore you and your seed; for, this is the
 justice of heaven."

⁵ "I *also* learned, my son Seth, that a Flood will come and purge the
 entire earth on account of the sons of Cain your brother. Because of
 his jealousy for Lebuda your sister, he murdered your brother Abel.
 Similarly, due to your mother Eve, sins came into existence. And,
 after the Flood, the years for the *continued* appearance of the world
 will be 6,000 years. And then its end will come."

⁶ And I, Seth, wrote down this testament. My father died and was
 buried east of Paradise, opposite the first city to be built on earth,
 which was named Enoch. Adam was accompanied *to the grave* by
 angels and heavenly powers because he was created in the image of
 God. The sun and moon grew dark and there was thick darkness for
 seven days. ⁷ We sealed the testament and placed it in the Cave of
 Treasures with the offerings that Adam had brought out from
 Paradise – gold, myrrh, and incense. And the Magi, the sons of
 kings, came and removed them, and brought them to the Son of God
 in the cave at Bethlehem of Judaea. Finished is the testament of our
 father Adam.

⁴ Reeves has 'descendants' in place of 'seed'.

⁵ Throughout this chapter, italicised words in the translation are enclosed in parentheses by Reeves.

⁶ The 'Cave of Treasures' is used as a title of a work that includes much of this document, along with many other texts.

⁷ Some online translations include this verse as part of v. 6.

❖ **האב וְהַיָּלֵף וְהַיָּלֵף וְהַיָּלֵף**

[illegible][illegible]

Also, the Testament of Our Father, Adam

¹ The heavenly powers: what they are like and how each of their ranks is occupied in the service and the plan of this world. Listen, my beloved, as they are set in rank one after another from the bottom, until we reach those who carry our Lord Jesus the Messiah and bear him up. ² The lowest rank is the angels. And the plan has been revealed to it by God concerning every human being whom they watch over, because one angel from this lowest rank accompanies every single human being in the world for his protection. And this is its service.

³ The second order is the [sacrifice of] archangels. This is the service: directing everything in this creation according to the plan of God, whether powers, or animals, or birds, or creeping things, or fish, as in their divisions, and to speak briefly and in short, whatever exists in this creation, except for human beings, they care for it and guide it.

⁴ The third order, which is the archons. This is its service: moving the air so that a cloud rises from the ends of the earth, according to the

TESTAMENT OF ADAM 4

¹ The ‘published translation’ has with ‘*order(s)*’ in place of ‘*rank(s)*’ throughout the chapter.

² The word here marked with '[?????]' is not recognized by the [OCR tool](#) used to convert the text from an image.

³ The 'published translation' does not have '*sacrifice of*' (which may be due to bad OCR conversion) or '*as in their divisions*'.

⁴ The text presented in (square) brackets is very uncertain – the OCR tool used seems to not recognize many of the characters.

[illegible][illegible]

**علم حسنة حة: زينة وحناء لحياتك
وتحفظك من آفة الذنوب**

⁸ The text presented in (square) brackets is very uncertain – the OCR tool used seems to not recognize many of the characters.